



LOWER HOUSE ROULETTE

JMM (5)*: Shibu Soren wants a MoS and a Cabinet berth. Congress hopes he will settle for the Coal Ministry.

TRS (2)*: Didn't get an assurance on Telangana. So will vote against. Also lobbied with the NDA but will finally align with Mayawati.

JD(U) (2)*: Deve Gowda wants a ministerial berth and a tie-up in Karnataka.

TRINAMOL CONGRESS (1)*: Wants the Congress to declare her outfit as the "mother party" in West Bengal.

NATIONAL CONFERENCE (2)*: Omar Abdullah is not bargaining but could be interested in a tie-up in J&K.

* Number of MPs

DIVIDED HOUSE:
Manmohan and Sonia (left); NDA leaders (below)



he recited his favourite demand for a separate state of Telangana. When the Congress hedged, Rao called BJP chief Rajnath Singh saying that if the BJP supported his demand for Telangana, he would join the NDA. But before Rajnath could reply, Rao had jumped onto Mayawati's bandwagon. As Sebastian Paul, independent MP from Kerala, quips, "Everyone wants statehood. Money is no longer the current currency."

The Congress is in a bind. The arithmetic of support is daunting. According to the current calculations, three-and-a-half MPs equal one ministerial berth. But now even parties with two MPs are demanding a ministry. JD(S) chief H.D. Deve Gowda rebuffed Congress emissary Pawan Bansal saying he would only talk to Sonia. Even after 40 minutes of cajoling by Ahmed Patel, Gowda did not commit. He is negotiating for a ministerial berth as well as a tie-up in Karnataka.

The NDA too had its heartbeat moments when the media speculated that the Shiromani Akali Dal and the Biju Janata Dal (BJD) would abstain from voting. However, by mid-week it seemed its flock was intact. Punjab Chief Minister Parkash Singh Badal called and assured Advani and BJP

The arithmetic of support is daunting with
EVERY SMALL PARTY ASKING FOR EITHER A
ministerial berth or a separate state.

issued its whip against the trust vote.

Adding to the babel was Rahul Gandhi who declared that the prime minister had taken the right decision. "I would tell him to take the risk again, again and again. That is leadership." The ringing endorsement may have calmed some nerves in South Block but the party is still worried. Despite the bravado, the UPA is still unsure of its numbers. "*Sab saudagar hain* (everyone is a merchant). We will not know till the night of July 21 who stands where," sighed a Congress general secretary. Dark humour apart, the Congress is hoping that no party will want to be seen triggering an early election and is betting on the fear factor—that nobody wants to go to polls now. Hope is resting on fear this weekend.

with bureau inputs